

Fontys HBO-ICT

Snapchat Hacking and Masking - User Manual

On behalf of the Rotterdam Police

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Version 2

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Version Control

Version	Date	Changelog
1	17/1/2026	First version of the document
2	22/1/2026	Added clarification that Platform Tools should be installed

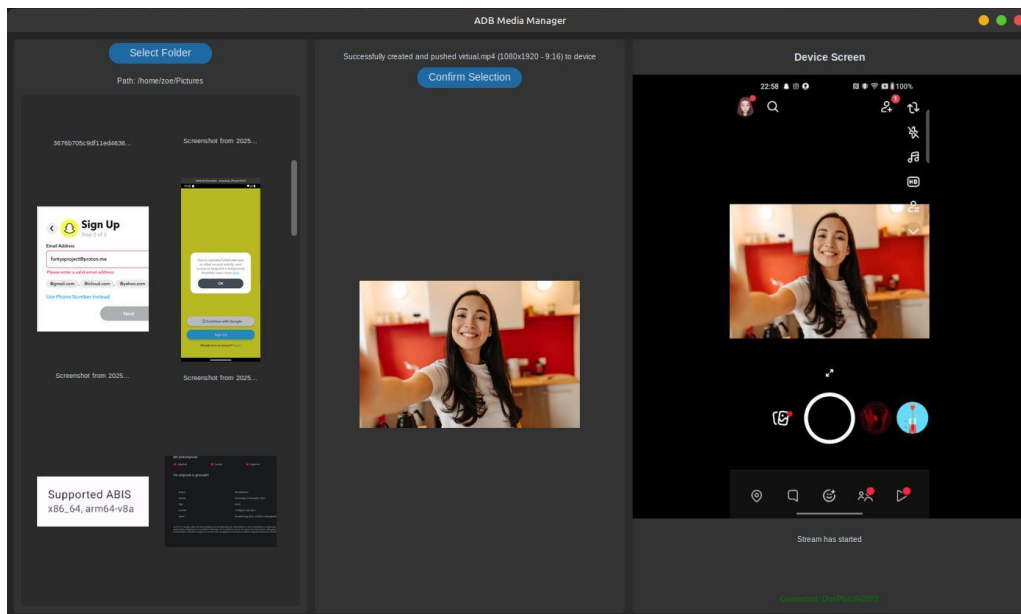
1. Introduction

The purpose of this document is to describe how to use and troubleshoot the GUI and possible phone warnings. This document assumes that all components (GUI and Android device) have been set up as per the Technical Guide. If this is not the case, please refer to the Technical Guide prior to following this guide.

Moreover, it is assumed that Platform Tools have been downloaded on the computer, and have been set up as Environment Variables, as explained in the Technical Guide.

2. Current environment

GUI with integrated phone screen copy:



On the left-hand side, is the folder selection menu, where all the images and videos are stored locally on your computer. Upon selecting the folder, a preview of the media will be displayed.

In the middle column, a preview of the selected media is displayed, and a button to confirm that this is the chosen media.

On the right side, is a copy of the Android device connected, for easy recording of conversations through the use of OBS or any other recording software, without alarming Snapchat that you are recording.

The screen displayed supports touch. You may interact with the phone in the window as you would interact with a normal phone. Limitations include the use of 1 finger at a time (1 mouse at a time). This means, that zooming in on the screen, needs to happen on the mobile device itself.

2.1 Supported file formats

Files (images, videos) that are accepted by the GUI are:

Images

- .jpg, .jpeg
- .png
- .gif
- .bmp
- .webp
- .tiff, .tif

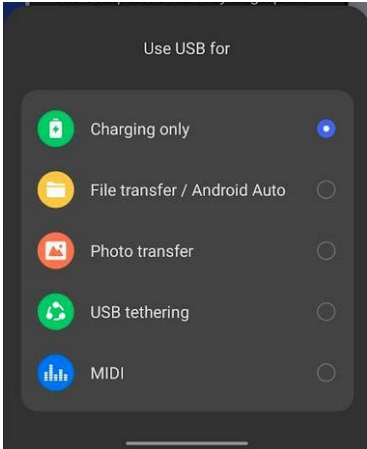
Videos (Under 60s)

- .mp4
- .mov
- .avi
- .mkv
- .webm
- .flv
- .wmv
- .m4v

3. User Guide

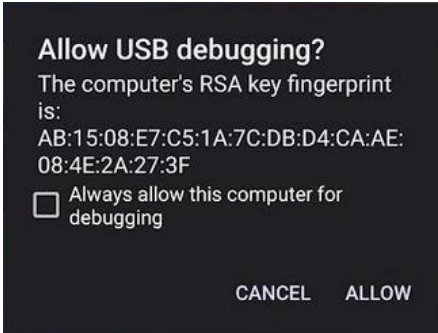
Connect the phone with a cable to the computer that has the GUI installed.

Upon connecting, you should receive the following notification on your phone:



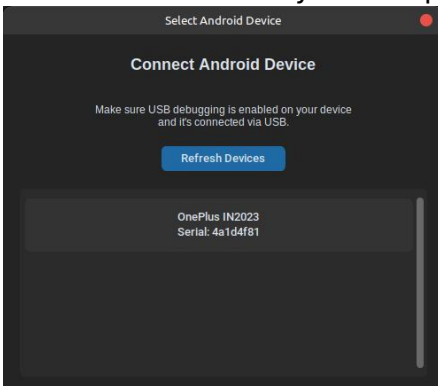
Click on “File transfer / Android Auto”. The pop-up will go away. If you happen to choose a different option, simply disconnect the phone and re-plug it into the computer.

Another notification will pop up:



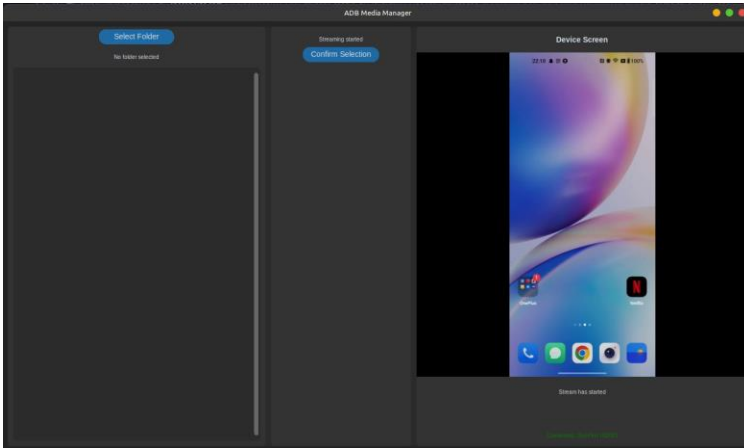
Select “Allow”.

Launch the GUI from your computer. The following window will open:



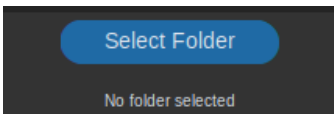
Select the phone currently being used in the investigation. Should there only be one Android phone connected to the computer, it is safe to assume that it is the one showing up in the dialog. Else, consult in your phone's setting's the name of your device. The name always includes the model/brand of phone.

The GUI will appear as soon as the phone is selected:

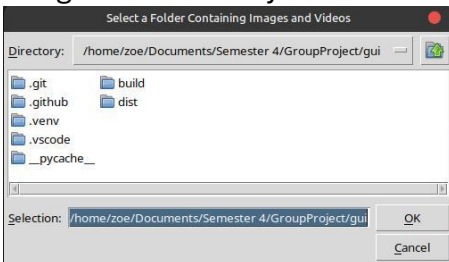


The screen of your Android device will be broadcasted on the right hand side of the GUI.

On the left hand side of the GUI, press the following button:

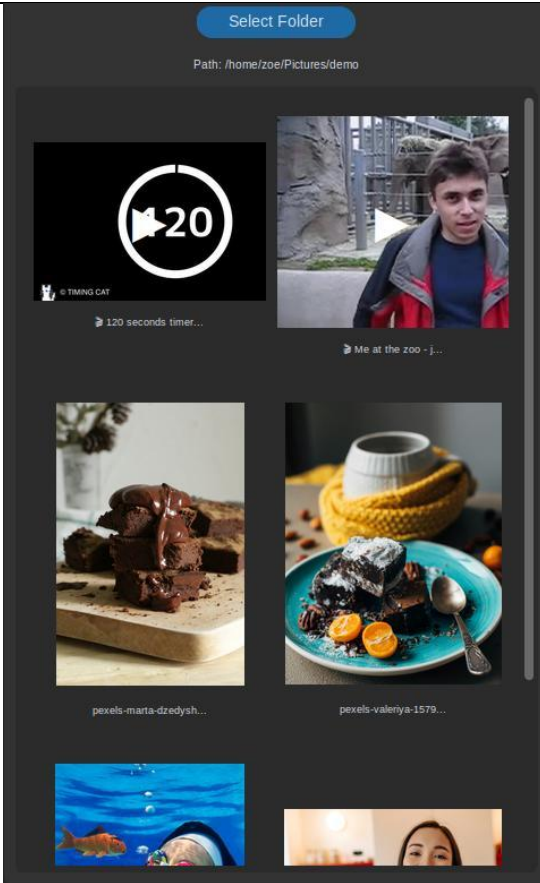


It will open a dialog, in which you navigate to the folder on your computer containing the images and videos you want to use:

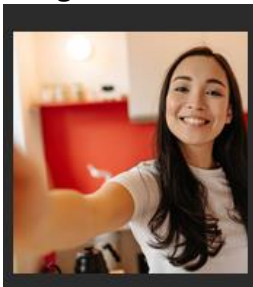


Navigate to the relevant folder you want to use and press "OK".

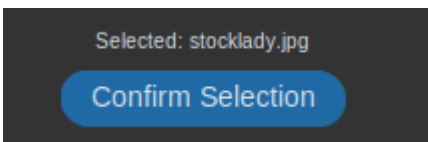
The left side of the GUI will then be populated with media from the chosen folder. If videos are included in the directory, it might take a moment to finish loading all the content. Eventually, you should be able to see all media from the chosen folder:



To upload either an image or a video to the device, the media should follow the restrictions mentioned in section “Restrictions”. Otherwise the GUI will throw an error. To upload the media to the device, click on the wanted file. For example, just click on this image:

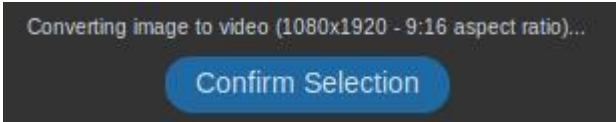


Once you have clicked on your chosen file, press “Confirm Selection”, from the middle column:

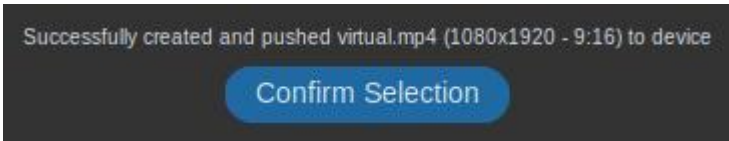


A preview will be shown below the button, so you know which image you clicked on and will be sending to the device

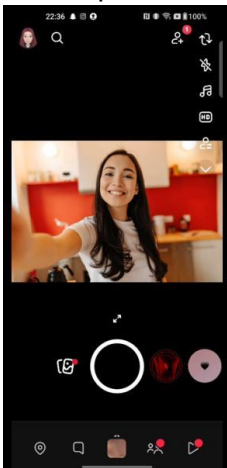
The status of the image will be displayed above the button after pressing it:



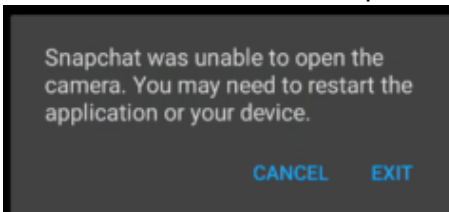
And then:



At this point, the image has been uploaded to the phone. Open Snapchat:



There is a chance that Snapchat will show the following warning:

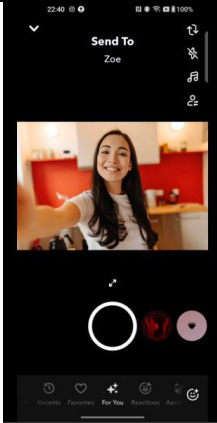


Simply go to the phone's homescreen (do not fully close the app), and relaunch Snapchat. The camera stream should now be replaced by the image or video you selected.

Enter the chat you wish to interact with and press on the camera icon to send an image or video:



The camera will see the image or video you have uploaded:



The image or video does not fill the screen, do not worry.

Simply take a picture as you normally would, by pressing the middle button:



You may apply filters as you normally would, before or after taking the image/video.

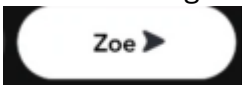
To take a video, long press the button, releasing the button once you have the video you want to send.

Upon taking the image, zoom into it, to fill the entire screen:



It is imperative to see the curved top and bottom corners within Snapchat's frame, as otherwise the image is not covering the entire screen, giving it a "fake" feeling.

Send the image or video to the target:



You have successfully sent the masked media:



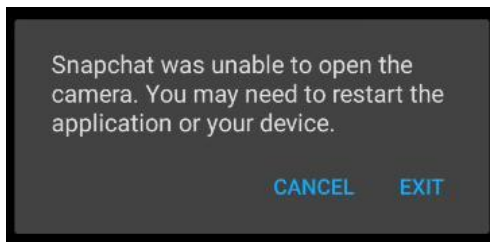
4. Update management

The phone should never be updated through the phone's update manager. Any updates should preferably be ignored, to keep the stability of the environment, as major changes have not tested yet. Should you have to update, e.g. Snapchat does not support the current Android version anymore, consult the Technical Guide.

Snapchat can be safely updated for the foreseeable future. This is because the VCAM module uses the Camera2 API, and as long as there is not a new version of that, this module has no reason to fail. For perspective, Camera1 was released with Android 1.5 in 2009 and remained supported for many years before Camera2 was introduced with Android 5.0 in 2014. Even after the introduction of Camera2, Camera1 compatibility layers continued to exist for legacy applications. Based on this historical precedent, it is highly unlikely that the Camera2 API will be deprecated or fundamentally altered in the near future.

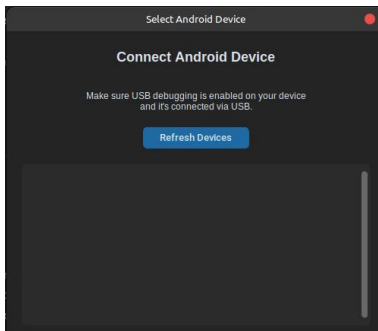
5. Troubleshooting

- When opening Snapchat, an error will show up if the app was fully closed before:



This is not an issue, just go to the home screen or drag up all active apps (do not fully close Snapchat), and then re-enter the application. This has to do with the Surface API and cannot be fixed, as it is a timing and attaching issue.

- The device selection dialog does not show the phone:



Reconnect the Android device and make sure that the dialog boxes have been correctly clicked, as shown in the guide. Refresh the devices list. If this still does not work, check if the cable is correctly attached to both the computer and device. If

that does not solve the issue, try a different cable. This should fix the issue most of the time. No other cases have been encountered yet.